# Azure Active Directory Quick Guide for Cloud Beginners

Azure Active Directory (Entra ID) is the central command center for identity and access in Microsoft Azure. Understanding how to manage users, groups, and permissions will save you hours of troubleshooting and keep your cloud safe.

**What you'll learn:**

1. Creating a New User Account
2. Organizing Users with Azure Groups
3. Assigning RBAC Permissions to Users
4. App Identities with Service Principals

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## Creating a New User Account

Every team member needs a unique digital identity before they can access Azure resources. Using the Azure CLI allows you to create user accounts in seconds rather than clicking through portal menus. Always generate a temporary password and require the user to change it upon their first sign-in for security.

```
$az ad user create --display-name "Alex Smith" --user-principal-name "alex@company.com" --password "T
```

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## Organizing Users with Azure Groups

Managing individual user permissions gets messy fast as your team grows. Groups allow you to bucket users together by department or project. When someone joins or leaves a project, you simply add or remove them from the group without touching individual resource permissions.

```
$az ad group create --display-name "Backend-Team" --mail-nickname "BackendTeam"
```

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## Assigning RBAC Permissions to Users

Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) decides what a user can actually do inside a subscription or resource group. Follow the rule of least privilege: grant only the minimum permissions necessary (like Reader or Contributor) to get the job done.

```
$az role assignment create --assignee "alex@company.com" --role "Reader" --resource-group "Production
```

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## App Identities with Service Principals

Applications and automation tools should never log in using human passwords. A Service Principal acts as a special non-human identity for software, allowing GitHub Actions or deployment scripts to interact with Azure safely.

```
$az ad sp create-for-rbac --name "DeploymentPipeline-SP" --role "Contributor" --scopes /subscriptions
```

See Key Takeaways on next page >> linkedin.com/in/mramanrajsingh

# Key Takeaways

+ Assign roles to groups rather than individual user accounts
+ Enforce Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) for all user accounts
+ Apply the principle of least privilege for every role assignment
+ Store Service Principal secret keys in Azure Key Vault securely
+ Regularly review and remove inactive users and guest accounts

## Watch Out For

! Hardcoding Service Principal passwords directly into git repositories
! Assigning Owner permissions to users for quick testing and forgetting to remove it
! Giving subscription-wide access when access to a single resource group is enough
! Using personal user accounts to run automated scripts and deployment pipelines

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